

Rainbow's End

A NOVEL

BY REX BEACH

Author of
"The Iron Trail," "The Spoilers,"
"Heart of the Sunset," etc.

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CHAPTER XVI.

The Trocha.

Of all the military measures employed by the Spaniards in their war against Cuban independence, perhaps the most unique was the trocha—trench or traverse. Martinez Campos during the Ten Years' war built the first trocha just west of the Cabañas mountains where the waist of the island is narrowest. Not until Weyler's time were the two methods of pacification, the trocha and the concentration camp, developed to their fullest extent. Although his trochas hindered the free movement of Cuban troops and his prison camps decimated the peaceful population of several provinces, the Spanish cause gained little. Both trenches and prison camps became Spanish graveyards.

At the time Johnnie O'Reilly set out for Matanzas the war—a war without battle, without victory, without defeat—had settled into a grim contest of endurance. In the east, where the insurgents were practically supreme, there was food of a sort, but beyond the Júcaro-Moron trocha—the old one of Campos' building—the country was sick. Immediately west of it, in that district which the Cubans called Las Villas, the land lay dying, while the entire provinces of Matanzas, Habana and Pinar del Rio were practically dead. These three were skeletons, picked bare of flesh by Weyler's beak. The Júcaro-Moron trocha had been greatly strengthened since Campos' day. It followed the line of the trans-isthmian railway. Dotted at every quarter of a mile along the grade were little forts connected by telephone and telegraph lines. Between these fortifications were sentry stations of logs or railroad ties. Eyes were keen, rifles were ready, challenges were sharp, and counter-signs were quickly given on the Júcaro-Moron trocha.

In O'Reilly's party there were three men besides himself—the ever-faithful Jacket, a wrinkled old Camagueyan who knew the bridge trails of his province as a fox knows the tracks to its lair, and a silent guajiro from farther west, detailed to accompany the expedition because of his wide acquaintance with the devastated districts. Both

surroundings. When the mosquitoes became unbearable he put on his trousers, with some reluctance and much ceremony.

Midnight brought a moist, warm breeze and a few formless clouds which served at times to dimly obscure the moon. Watching the clouds, O'Reilly hoped that they might prove to be the heralds of a storm. None came. When the moon had finally crept down into the treetops old Hilario stepped upon his cigarette, then began silently to saddle up. The others followed with alacrity, and fell in behind him as he led the way into the forest.

When they had covered a couple of miles Hilario reined in and the others crowded close. Ahead, dimly discernible against the night sky, there appeared to be a thinning of the woods. After listening for a moment or two, Hilario dismounted and slipped away; the three riders sat their saddles with ears strained.

Hilario returned with word that all was well, and each man dismounted to muffle the feet of his horse with rags and strips of gunny-sack provided for the purpose. Then, one by one, they moved forward to the edge of the clearing. The trocha lay before them. O'Reilly felt a pair of reins thrust into his hand and found Hilario examining a large pair of tinners' shears. "Do you wish me to go with you?" he inquired of the guide.

The latter shook his head. "Antonio will go; he will keep watch while I clear a path. If anything goes wrong, wait here. Don't ride away until we have time."

"Never fear. I won't desert you," the American reassured him. The two white-clad figures slipped away, became indistinct, and then disappeared. The night was hot, the mosquitoes hummed dully and settled in clouds upon the waiting pair, maddening them with their poison. A half-hour passed, then the two ghostly figures materialized once more.

"Dios!" grumbled Hilario. "There are many strings to this Spanish guitar. What a row when they discover that I have played a Cuban dance upon it!" The old man seemed less sure than before.

"Is the way clear?" O'Reilly inquired. "As far as the railroad, yes. We heard voices there, and came back. We will have to cut our way forward after we cross the track. Now, then, follow me without a sound."

Leading his horse by the bit ring, Hilario moved out into the clearing, followed once more by his three companions. In spite of all precautions the animals made a tremendous racket, or so it seemed, and, despite Hilario's twisting and turnings, it was impossible to avoid an occasional loop of barbed wire, therefore flesh and clothing suffered grievously. But at length the party brought up under the railroad embankment and paused. As carefully as might be the four men ascended the slope, crossed the rails and descended into the ditch on the other side. Another moment and they encountered a taut strand of barbed wire. The metallic snip of Hilario's shears sounded like a pistol shot to O'Reilly. Into the maze of strands they penetrated, yard by yard, clipping and carefully laying

his weapon to his shoulder and firing it calmed him. The kick of the gun subdued his excitement and cleared his brain. He surprised himself by directing Jacket in a cool, authoritative voice, to shoot low. When he had emptied the magazine he led two of the horses forward. Then, grasping his own machete, he joined in clearing a pathway.

It seemed an interminable time ere they had extricated themselves from the trap, but finally they succeeded and gained the welcome shelter of the woods, pausing inside its shelter to cut the muffs from their horses' feet. By this time the defenders of the trocha, were pouring volley after volley at random into the night.

Now that the skirmish was over, Jacket began to boast of his part in it. "Ha! Perhaps they'll know better than to show themselves the next time I come this way," said he. "You saw me, didn't you? Well, I made a few Spanish widows tonight."

When no one disputed his assertion Jacket proceeded further in praise of himself, only to break off with a wordless cry of dismay.

"What's the matter?" Johnnie inquired.

"Look! Behold me!" wailed the hero. "I have left the half of my beautiful trousers on that barbed wire!" Antonio swung a leg over his saddle, saying: "Come along, amigos; we have fifty leagues ahead of us. The war will be over while we stand here gossiping."

O'Reilly's adventures on his swift ride through Las Villas have no part in this story. It is only necessary to say that they were numerous and varied, that O'Reilly experienced excitement plenty and that upon more than one occasion he was forced to think and to act quickly in order to avoid a clash with some roving guerrilla band.

Food became a problem immediately after the travelers had crossed the trocha. Such apprehensive families as still lurked in the woods were liberal enough—Antonio, by the way, knew all of them—but they had little to give, and, in consequence, O'Reilly's party learned the taste of wild fruits, berries and palmetto hearts. Once they managed to kill a small pig, the sole survivor of some obscure country tragedy, but the rest of the time their meat, when there was any, consisted of iguanas—those big, repulsive lizards—and jutias, the Cuban field rats.

Fortunately there was no shortage of food for the horses, and so, despite the necessity of numerous detours, the party made good time. They crossed into Matanzas, pushed on over rolling hills, through sweeping savannas, past empty clearings and deserted villages, to their journey's end. A fortunate encounter with a rebel patilla from General Betancourt's army enabled them to reach headquarters without loss of time, and one afternoon, worn, haggard and hungry, they dismounted in front of that gallant officer's hut.

General Betancourt read the letter which O'Reilly handed him, then looked up with a smile. "So! You are one of Gomez' Americans, eh? Well, I would never have known it, to look at you; the sun and the wind have made you into a very good Cuban. And your clothes—One might almost mistake you for a Cuban cabinet officer."

O'Reilly joined in the laughter evoked by this remark. He was quite as tattered as the poorest of Betancourt's common soldiers; his shoes were broken and disreputable; his cotton trousers, snagged by barbed wire and brambles, and soiled by days in the saddle and nights in the grass, were in desperate need of attention. His beard had grown, too, and his skin, where it was exposed, was burnt to a mahogany brown. Certainly there was nothing about his appearance to bespeak his nationality.

The general continued: "I am directed in this letter to help you in some enterprise. Command me, sir."

As briefly as possible Johnnie made known the object of his journey. The officer nodded his comprehension, but as he did so a puzzled expression crossed his face.

"Yes, I reported that Miss Varona had gone into the city—I took some pains to find out. Do you have reason to doubt—"

"Not the least, sir."

"Then—why have you come all this way?"

"I came to find her and to fetch her to her brother."

"But—you don't understand. She is actually inside the lines, in Matanzas—a prisoner."

"Exactly. I intend to go into Matanzas and bring her out."

General Betancourt drew back, astonished. "My dear man!" he exclaimed. "Are you mad?"

O'Reilly smiled faintly. "Quite probably. All lovers are mildly mad, I believe."

"Ah! Lovers! I begin to see. But—how do you mean to go about this—this impossible undertaking?"

"You told me just now that I could pass for a Cuban. Well, I am going to put it to the test. If I once get into the city I shall manage somehow to get out again, and bring her with me."

"Um-m!" The general appraised O'Reilly speculatively. "No doubt you can get in—it is not so difficult to enter, I believe, and especially to one who speaks the language like a native. But the return—I fear you will find that another matter. Matanzas is a place of pestilence, hunger, despair. No one goes there from choice any more, and no one ever comes out."

"So I should imagine." The speaker's careless tone added to General Betancourt's astonishment. "Bless me!" he exclaimed. "What an extraordinary young man! Is it possible that you do not comprehend the terrible conditions?"

A sudden thought struck him and he inquired quickly: "Tell me, you are not by any chance that hero they call El Demonio? I have heard that he is indeed a demon. No? Very well! You say you wish to visit Matanzas, and I am instructed to help you. How can I do so?"

O'Reilly hesitated an instant. "For one thing, I need money. I—I haven't a single peseta."

"You are welcome to the few dollars I possess."

(Continued in next issue.)

The warrants authorized will be retired at the rate of \$1000 per year for a term of seven years.

EVEN THE MOVIES ARE DEPENDENT FOR LIFE ON MEAT PACKERS

WASHINGTON, Aug. 4.—It is impossible to go to the movies and forget how much it costs to live. The movies themselves, it became known today at the federal trade commission, are dependent on the packers.

Federal trade commission investigators found that the film used for motion pictures and phonograph disks as well as composed largely of by-products of the meat-packing industry.

BRAKEMAN LOSES TOP OF HEAD BETWEEN TWO LOGS AT ASTORIA

ASTORIA, Aug. 5.—Frank Anderson, a brakeman on the Western Cooperative company's logging train, was instantly killed while at work Monday. A trainload of logs was being hauled from the California Barrel company's camp when one log dropped down and displaced the load on the two cars behind. Anderson was caught between two logs and the top of his head was pinched off. Anderson was 23 years old.

100,000 Mines Must Be Swept From Sea

LONDON, Aug. 4.—The final grand mine sweep is being made in the North sea. One hundred thousand mines remain to be swept up from the great barrage extending from the tip of Scotland to Norway and down along the German coast, and the work is being done equally by British and American forces. The work is expected to be completed by December, although "strays" which have broken from their moorings may continue to menace shipping for several years more. Some 400 British mine sweepers are busy every day the weather permits—and that's most every day—in the North sea. The personnel comprises 15,000. The base of the American mine sweepers is off the Orkneys.

Soviet Government

The demand of the Brotherhood of Railway Trainmen for an equal voice in the operation and management of railroads, along with the government and the actual owners of the roads, is nothing short of a soviet movement in this country, and has been brought about by the weak and vacillating policy of the administration in dealing with railroad labor problems.

The railroads of this country are privately owned, and up to the time the operation of them was taken over by the government as a war emergency act, they were managed by their owners, under federal regulation as to rates and in other ways, and the public received a maximum service at a minimum cost.

We have had a fair trial of government operation of railroads, and ever since the armistice was signed, the public has been clamoring for a return of the roads to the control of and operation by their owners.

The people of the United States may well consider the seriousness of the demands of the trainmen. We have a highly specialized organization of well paid men, without a dollar invested in the property of their employers, insisting upon a program of trio-operation, with labor representing a full third.

If this is not soviet government, then what is it? Certainly a step well toward national socialism and not far removed from Bolshevism.

The question is now up to the administration and to congress, and has resolved itself into a situation that will require delicate handling to avoid the precipitation of a nation-wide industrial crisis and the paralyzing of traffic.

TRANS-ATLANTIC FLIER WILL VISIT OREGON DURING NEW FLIGHT

WASHINGTON, Aug. 4.—It has been decided by the navy department that the NC-4, first airplane to cross the Atlantic, will be sent to the Pacific Coast. The transcontinental flight details are now being worked out. It is expected the flight will be from New York to San Francisco with side trips to Portland, Seattle, Los Angeles and other cities. It is not yet decided who will pilot the NC-4 across the country. Commander Read, who made with this machine a successful flight across the Atlantic in May, will be either in command, or a special observer and adviser.

THIRTY-FIVE DEAD AS RESULT OF STONE THROWN IN CHICAGO

CHICAGO, Aug. 2.—George Stauber, 23, said by the police to be the white man who threw a stone at Eugene Williams, negro, at a South Side bathing beach last Sunday, thereby causing the race riots in this city which resulted in the death of 25 persons and the injuring of 300, was arraigned in the South Clark street police station late today on a charge of murder. Judge Newcomer continued his case until August 19, fixing Stauber's bond at \$50,000. According to the police, the stone thrown by Stauber struck the negro, knocking him from a raft and causing him to drown.

UNCLE SAM WILL SELL ARMY FOOD AT COST, DELIVER IT BY MAIL

WASHINGTON, Aug. 4.—Prices at which army surplus food stocks will be put on sale direct to the public in the big cities were announced as follows:

Meats—Corned beef, No. 1, can, 30 cents; No. 2, can, 28 cents; six-pound can, \$2. Roast beef, No. 1, can, 29 cents; 1-pound can, 41 cents; 2-pound can, 66 cents; six-pound can, \$2.20. Corn beef hash, one-pound, 23 cents; two-pound can, 40 cents. Bacon, in crates, 34 cents per pound. In 12-pound tins, 36 cents per pound.

Vegetables—Baked beans, No. 1, can, 7 cents; No. 2, can, 13 cents. No. 3, 18 cents. Stringless beans, No. 2, can, 11 cents; No. 3, can, 48 cents. Corn, No. 2, can, 12 cents. Peas, No. 2, can, 11 cents. Tomatoes, No. 2, can, 11 cents. No. 2½, can, 13 cents. No. 3, can, 15 cents. No. 10, can, 46 cents. Pumpkin, No. 2, can, 6 cents; No. 3, can, 9 cents. No. 10, can, 24 cents. Squash, No. 2, can, 6 cents.

PIONEER DOCTOR OF ALBANY SUPPOSED ON OUTING IS FOUND DEAD

ALBANY, Aug. 4.—Dr. J. Linsey Hill, one of Oregon's pioneer physicians, was found dead in his rooms late Sunday night and had evidently been dead since July 24, when he was supposed to have left for an outing at Breitenbush Springs. Members of his family had been with him during the evening of July 23 and assisted in packing his camping outfit, which was taken to the train.

His sister, who lives next door, and his daughter, who lives in the next block and with whom he took his meals, had timed their vacations to be away at the same time and left on the morning of July 24. Upon their return Sunday evening it was learned that Dr. Hill had not been at Breitenbush and an investigation disclosed that he had died, probably Thursday morning, while dressing for his trip.

Two rare pearl earrings, low-necked blouse, oblong collar of gold, set with jewels, and false red hair were some of the things Queen Elizabeth wore in her 67th year.



Hard Riding Brought the Party to the Trocha.

guides, having crossed the trocha more than once, affected to scorn its terrors, and their easy confidence reassured O'Reilly in spite of Esteban's parting admonition.

The American had not dreamed of taking Jacket along, but when he came to announce his departure the boy had flatly refused to be left behind.

Fifty miles of hard riding brought the party to the trocha; they neared it on the second morning after leaving Cabañas, and sought a secluded camping spot. Later in the day Hilario, the old Camagueyan, slipped away to reconnoiter. He returned at twilight, but volunteered no report of what he had discovered. After an insistent cross-examination O'Reilly wrung from him the reluctant admission that everything seemed favorable for a crossing some time that night, and that he had selected a promising point. Beyond that the old man would say nothing.

Supper, a simple meal, was quickly disposed of. Then followed a long, dispiriting wait, for a gibbous moon rode high in the sky and the guides refused to stir so long as it remained there. It was a still night; in the jungle no air was stirring, and darkness brought forth a torment of mosquitoes. As day died the woods awoke to sounds of bird and insect life; strange, raucous calls peened forth, some familiar, others strange and unaccustomed. Sitting there in the dark, bedeviled by a pest of insects, mocked at by these mysterious voices, and looking forward to a hazardous enterprise, O'Reilly began to curse his vivid imagination and to envy the impassiveness of his companions. Even Jacket, he noted, endured the strain better; the boy was cheerful, philosophical, quite unimpressed by his



Into the Maze of Strands They Penetrated.

back the wire as they went. Progress was slow; they had to feel their way; the sharp barbs brought blood and muttered profanity at every step.

None of the four ever knew what gave the alarm. Their first intimation of discovery came with a startling "Quien vive?" hurled at them from somewhere at their backs.

An instant and the challenge was followed by a Mauser shot. Other reports rang out as the sentry emptied his rifle in their direction.

"So! They are shooting bats!" Hilario grunted.

Antonio swung about and cocked his Remington, but the other spoke sharply. "Fool! If you shoot they will see the fire and riddle us. A curse on the spider that spun this web!"

It was a test of courage to crouch among the charred stumps, enmeshed in that cruel tangle of wire, while the night was stabbed by daggers of fire and while the trocha awoke to the wild alarm. From somewhere in the distance came a shouted command and the sound of running feet, suddenly putting an end to further loquacity. Antonio began to hack viciously with his machete, in an effort to aid Hilario's labors. The sound of his sturdy blows betrayed the party's whereabouts so clearly that finally the older man could restrain himself no longer.

"Give it to them, compadres; it is a game that we can play!"

O'Reilly had been gripping his rifle tensely, his heart in his throat, his pulses pounding. As near a panic as he had ever been, he found, oddly enough, that the mere act of throwing



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